TRG Guidelines of Conduct 2026–27

Conduct, communication and support

Purpose
A short shared guide to how we work together in TRG: good science, clear communication, mutual respect and taking responsibility for our own work.

1. Respect and communication

We should be able to discuss science openly, disagree and challenge each other's ideas. That is part of research. Communication should still remain respectful and focused on the work, whether in person, by email, online or with collaborators.

- Ask before assuming that someone has done something wrong or failed to do something.
- Disagree with the science or the decision, not the person.
- Be mindful of tone as well as content and give people reasonable time to respond.
- If something is unclear or not working, raise it early and clearly.

2. Meetings and working together

Meetings are there to share progress, solve problems and agree what happens next. Come prepared, listen to each other and keep discussions constructive.

- Give everyone space to speak and explain their reasoning.
- If there is disagreement, discuss it properly and either reach a decision or agree how it will be taken forward.
- If a discussion becomes unproductive or disrespectful, the meeting may be paused or ended.
- Key decisions may be recorded in writing after a meeting so that everyone has a clear record of what was agreed. If needed, future discussions may also take place in writing or with another suitable person involved.

3. Progress, deadlines and working arrangements

Everyone is responsible for their own progress, agreed actions and communication.

- Keep track of deadlines and regular updates that have been agreed.
- If a deadline is likely to slip, say so early and suggest a realistic new plan.
- Remote or flexible working is fine where agreed and appropriate, but it still means remaining reasonably contactable and keeping people updated.
- If you know you will be unavailable during your usual working hours, please add this to the group calendar so that others know when you are not contactable.
- Holidays and leave should be requested through the appropriate University process. There is no expectation to reply outside normal working hours unless something different has been agreed.
- Repeated missed deadlines, lack of engagement or poor communication may need to be addressed more formally.

4. Scientific direction, authorship, data and collaboration

Independent thinking is encouraged, but there also needs to be clarity about responsibility for project guidance, research materials and external communication.

- The PI is responsible for the overall guidance and management of TRG research projects, including project priorities and group resources, while independent scientific thinking and intellectual contribution are encouraged.
- Once a decision has been discussed and agreed, it is expected to be followed. Any concern should be raised through the appropriate route rather than repeatedly reopening the same decision.
- Authorship, manuscript review and submission should follow University and journal requirements. Drafts should be shared with the relevant authors and supervisors with enough time for proper review.
- Collaborative work is strongly encouraged, but significant external communication about TRG projects should be coordinated with the PI and relevant collaborators. Students should not independently request unpublished material, make commitments on behalf of a project, or agree authorship, publication or dissemination arrangements without prior discussion with the PI.
- Research data, code, scripts, workflows and other research materials should be clearly documented and stored in University approved locations, with appropriate access and retention arrangements. They should not be held only on personal devices, personal cloud services or accounts that may become inaccessible after completion or departure.
- Ownership and permitted use of research outputs and intellectual property are determined by the University Intellectual Property Policy and, where applicable, funding, collaboration, sponsorship or other agreements. The research group must retain sufficient access to the research record for verification, publication, reproducibility and research integrity purposes.

5. Wellbeing, personal circumstances and support

If health, wellbeing or personal circumstances are affecting work or communication, please raise this when you can. There is no need to share private medical or personal details with the group.

- Formal support plans and reasonable adjustments will be respected and supported alongside the relevant University services.
- If circumstances affect a deadline or agreed action, let the relevant people know as early as reasonably possible so that support or a revised plan can be considered.
- Adjustments may change how support, meetings or communication are provided, but respectful communication and reasonable engagement still apply to everyone.
- Where specialist support is needed, the appropriate University service should be involved. TRG itself does not assess or manage medical or mental health conditions.

6. Raising concerns and resolving difficulties

If something is not working, raise it early and focus on the specific issue. The aim is to understand what has happened and find a practical way forward.

- Scientific or project concerns should normally be raised with the relevant supervisor or PI.
- If an issue cannot be resolved directly, an appropriate third person may be involved, such as a co supervisor, or PGR representative, to help clarify the issue and agree a way forward.
- Where a meeting would not be useful or appropriate, communication can continue in writing through an agreed route.
- If agreed arrangements or expectations around communication and conduct are repeatedly not followed, the issue may need to be documented and taken through the appropriate University route.

TRG principle Be clear. Be respectful. Take responsibility. Raise problems early. Support and professional responsibility work both ways.

University policy basis

These guidelines should be read alongside the University Supervision Policy for Postgraduate Research Degrees, Publications Policy, Intellectual Property Policy, Research Data Management requirements and any applicable funding, collaboration, confidentiality or sponsorship agreement.